Historicity of Jesus

The Bible is not for stupid gullible people, the Bible is for intelligent people who are persuaded by the weight of evidence. Many religions are based on “blind faith,” whereas Christianity on the other hand has sufficient evidence and some, to support its practice.

If the New Testament wasn’t available you could piece together the basic narrative of the Gospel from these ancient Anti-Christian sources.

ANCIENT PAGAN SOURCES; (Anit-Chrisitian)

Tacitus (AD 56-117)

Tacitus was ancient Rome’s greatest historian. He was also an orator and public official. Most of what we learned about the Roman emperors in high school comes from him.

Annals 15.44

"Consequently, to get rid of the report, Nero fastened the guilt and inflicted the most exquisite tortures on a class hated for their abominations, called Christians by the populace. Christus, from whom the name had its origin, suffered the extreme penalty during the reign of Tiberius at the hands of one of our procurators, Pontius Pilatus, and a most mischievous superstition, thus checked for the moment, again broke out not only in Judea, the first source of the evil, but even in Rome, where all things hideous and shameful from every part of the world find their centre and become popular."

Mara bar Serapion (AD 73 ish)

Mara bar Serapion was a Syrian who lived in the first century. The letter is now in the possession of the British Museum.

“What advantage did the Athenians gain by murdering Socrates, for which they were repaid with famine and pestilence? Or the Samos by the burning of Pythagoras, because their country was completely covered in sand in just one hour? What advantage did the Jews gain from executing their wise King? It was just after that that their kingdom was abolished... But Socrates did not die altogether; he lived on in the teaching of Plato, Pythagoras did not die altogether; he lived on in the statue of Hera. Nor did the wise king die altogether; he lived on in the teaching which he had given.”

Pliny the Younger (AD 112)

Pliny was a wealthy Roman administrator stationed in northern Turkey. In AD 110, he wrote to Emperor Trajan asking for advice on how to deal with the Christians. He’s asking whether he should continue executing the followers of Christ.

“The sum total of their guilt or error was no more than the following. They had met regularly before dawn on a determined day, and sung alternately a hymn to Christ as to a god. They also took an oath not for any crime, but to keep from theft, robbery and adultery, and not to break any promise.”

Suetonius (AD 120)

A Roman historian and annalist of the Imperial House under the Emperor Hadrian. He refers to Christ and Christians and the "disturbances" caused by them, namely not worshipping idols.

"Because the Jews at Rome caused constant disturbances at the instigation of Chrestus [Christ], he [Claudius] expelled them from the city [Rome]." (see Acts 18:2)

ANCIENT JEWISH SOURCES; (Anti-Chrisitian)

Flavius Josephus (AD 37-101)

Josephus was born in Jerusalem a few years after Jesus' death. He was a Jewish aristocrat and military historian.

Jewish Antiquities, 18.63-64

"Now there was about this time Jesus, a wise man, if it be lawful to call him a man; for he was a doer of wonderful works, a teacher of such men as receive the truth with pleasure. He drew over to him both many of the Jews and many of the Gentiles. He was [the] Christ. And when Pilate, at the suggestion of the principal men amongst us, had condemned him to the cross, those that loved him at the first did not forsake him; for he appeared to them alive again the third day; as the divine prophets had foretold these and ten thousand other wonderful things concerning him. And the tribe of Christians, so named from him, are not extinct at this day. "

Jewish Antiquities, 20.200

In the following citation, Josephus describes the deeds of Ananus, the high priest of Jerusalem, and his treatment of James, the brother of Jesus.

"But this younger Ananus, who, as we have told you already, took the high priesthood, was a bold man in his temper, and very insolent... He assembled the Sanhedrin of judges, and brought before them the brother of Jesus the so-called Messiah-Christ, whose name was James, and some others. When he had formed an accusation against them as breakers of the law, he delivered them over to be stoned to death."

Talmud (AD 100-200)

The following reference comes from the Talmud, an ancient exposition of Jewish law. Here we find a report of Jesus' crimes, trial and execution.

Talmud (baraitha Sanhedrin 43a-b)

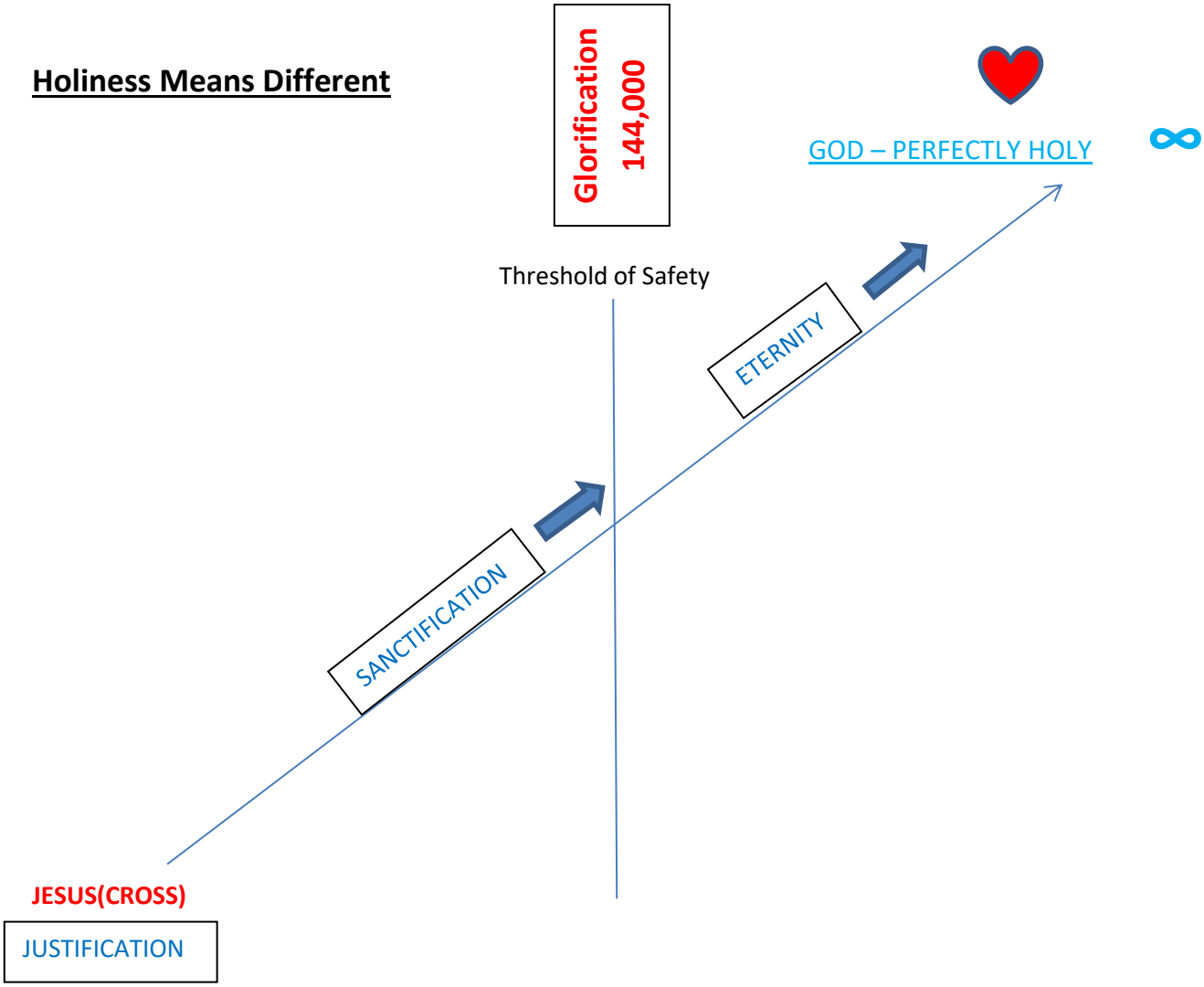
"On the eve of Passover Jesus was hanged (on a cross). For forty days before the execution took place, a herald went forth and cried, 'He is going forth to be stoned because he has practised sorcery and enticed and led Israel astray. Anyone who can say anything in his favour, let him come forward

and plead on his behalf.' But since nothing was brought forward in his favour, he was hanged on the eve of Passover."

These Greco-Roman and Jewish references provide critical information. It is worth listing the significant details about Jesus we may glean from these non-Christian texts:

- The name of 'Jesus'
- The place and time-frame of His public ministry (Palestine during Pontius Pilate's governorship, AD 26-36)
- The name of one of His brothers (James)
- His fame as a teacher
- His fame as a miracle-worker/sorcerer
- The attribution to Him of the title 'Messiah/Christ'
- His 'kingly' status in the eyes of some
- The time and manner of his execution (crucifixion around the Passover festival)
- The involvement of both the Roman and Jewish leadership in his death
- The report of Jesus' appearances to his followers after His death
- The flourishing of a movement that worshipped Jesus after His death

Holiness Means Different



Rom 8:29-31; 1 Pet 3:21;

Col 3:1-5 – Past is taken care of, Present is secure, Future is guaranteed – the only thing that can give you moral power to gain victory over sin is your confidence of your connection with God.

FIVE POINTS OF CALVANISM

T total depravity

U unconditional election∞∞∞∞∞∞

L limited atonement

I irresistible

P perserverence of the saints